States to see if we could help settle the dispute between mutual friends.

With this in mind, I asked Al Haig to try to mediate the dispute and avert an armed clash. He shuttled between Washington, London, and Buenos Aires for most of the next three weeks, making a valiant effort to avoid a war. Nevertheless, hostilities erupted on the first of May. I think Al had been caught between an immovable object and an irresistible force: Splintered badly and trying to whip up a jingoistic fervor to increase its own sagging popularity, the junta rejected any settlement that stopped short of unquestioned Argentinean sovereignty over the Falklands; Margaret Thatcher was willing to make limited concessions to avoid bloodshed, but was adamant in her determination to defend British interests.

As the Royal Navy sailed toward the Falklands, we learned that Soviet ships were trailing the British vessels and providing intelligence information about the fleet to Argentina via Cuba. We also learned that the Soviets offered to supply low-cost arms to Argentina if war broke out—an offer which, to its credit (and with encouragement from us), the junta refused.

Despite reports to the contrary in *The Washington Post* and elsewhere, we maintained a genuine as well as an official neutrality during this period. Although London utilized one of our military satellites to communicate with its fleet as it headed for the Falk-lands, this was done under an agreement that had been in effect long before the crisis. We provided no other military assistance to the British. However, once fighting started, after the Argentineans had repeatedly rejected reasonable offers of a settlement, we declared our full support of Britain and provided her with whatever aid we could.

What had been a war of nerves and a battle of words quickly became very bloody: Britain and Argentina each lost